Batting at the top of the order is an expression of individuality. When you're young, it is the equivalent of being the kid in the football team who plays centre forward. Opening is regarded as a bit of a status symbol, but as you progress the better players fancy going in at three or four. I had a spell, coming in first wicket down against Pakistan in the summer of 2006, and quite enjoyed it.

The openers' co-operative is convened in the manner of the goalkeepers' union. We are united by the disadvantage of fronting up when the bowler is fast and fresh, and the ball is hard and new. There are unspoken responsibilities to those who follow us to the crease. Our failure increases the likelihood of their failure; our success gives them breathing room.

We tend not to be show ponies. We have the hardiness of National Hunt racehorses, rather than the five-furlong flashiness of thoroughbreds on the flat. We're not dull, but we make a living through dependability. We live for the days when calmness settles, and something intangible suggests the scene is set for profit and plunder.

Such an experience also forms part of baseball's mystique, where batters deal with the deceptive angles and speeds of a ball thrown from a mound sixty feet away. Batters who have 0.413 seconds to react to a 100 mph fastball speak of 'feel', an instinct that defies deep analysis. It's a hard sport, one that doesn't encourage hippy-dippy romanticism, but the occurrence is commonly described as entering another dimension.

There's a lot of talk about mental toughness, but what does that really mean? To me, it involves wringing the maximum out of your natural ability at the most important moments on the biggest stages. Opening is suited to the more literal thinker, the individual who can place an innings, good or bad, in a box and hide the key. Failure must never be allowed to fester.

I took joy in finding the rhythm of my batting, the bass line that set the tempo. The job wasn't easy (that word rarely features in the vocabulary of any professional athlete), but it was occasionally effortless. I have a lot of moving parts to my technique, so I've got to get my hands and feet working in harmony.

A lot can go wrong in those four-tenths of a second. A lot must go right. That synchronicity is very, very enjoyable. You know, when you get to between 30 and 40, that a big score is on the cards. Suddenly, time accelerates, almost into double motion. Those are the occasions you look up